Tomorrow is the eve of Pesach. In my uncle's village, where I stayed during the first years of my life in Israel (from 1948 to 1951), its German and Czech inhabitants did not particularly observe the traditional ritual of Haggadah reading and, if they did, they did it for the enjoyment of the children. In short, I do not remember any particular attachment to religion. In some kibbutzim, particularly of the Marxist Hashomer Hatzair, the Haggadah had been rewritten in the national-political spirit of the times. This was not the general picture of course, but the Israel of those years was in majority secular or, at most, moderately observant for the sake of tradition. All of this changed, as we saw, first in 1967, and more thoroughly in 1977. Yet it is only now that the membership of the radical ultrareligious parties in the coalition has created a dangerous situation because of their relentless activism.

For the opposition, the threat of religious compulsion, of Israel turning into a theocracy, may be as obnoxious as the possibility of dictatorship. It is hard to see how youth who for the most part grew up in total religious freedom will submit to religious laws and edicts.

In Poland (I do not know about Hungary) the population has remained fervently Catholic, so the above may not have been a major obstacle to Jarosław Kaczyński's regime change. Actually, the governing party uses the defense of Pope John Paul II (against allegations that he covered up pedophilia cases among Polish priests while archbishop of Krakow) as a major propaganda theme in this election year. Traditional Catholic piety is at the core of Polish identity.

Tension between Ben-Gvir and Shabtai about who will have authority over a National Guard remains unresolved.

Wednesday, April 5